seconds that they gained by slowing the Chinese attack gave both Dashrath and Pant a chance to get their men organized. The initial rush on both these platoons was stemmed as the Chinese took severe casualties. As per Chinese records, the battalion commander leading the assault was also killed during this initial exchange of fire. Once again, though troops continued to be engaged in close-quarter duels, there was a momentary lull as the Chinese took stock.

Pant was everywhere, and he yelled across to Dashrath: ‘Ab mein kya karu? Aap to purane aadmi hein (What should I do now? You have been in these situations before)’. Before Dashrath could reply, the second wave of attacks began, pushing the JCO back to his own men where he could be heard shouting instructions over the din of gunfire. Charlie Company’s No. 7 Platoon that was closest to the Nam Ka Chu was now at the rear end of the battle.

The moment the firing had started, Second Lieutenant Onkar Dubey grabbed an LMG and along with two men rushed uphill to try and support Roshan’s section. By then the Chinese were already streaming past along the flanks and had engaged the other two platoons. Taking up a position on the flank behind some trees, Dubey and his two companions inflicted quite a few casualties. However, they were severely outnumbered by the onrushing Chinese. Both his companions were killed and Dubey was shot in the stomach and chest.

Pant, meanwhile, had been hit in the leg, but he was still exhorting his remaining men to fight on even though most of the platoon had been wiped out. According to Rikh’s notes: ‘The enemy after having been beaten back started more intensive firing on the locality. During this the officer was again seriously injured in the right leg and stomach. He kept on shouting at and inspiring his men who rose to superhuman heights and broke up the fourth wave of the enemy. The enemy saw that the officer was the main cause for the heavy casualties being inflicted on them, accordingly directed maximum fire on Major Pant who being hit all over his body, succumbed to his injuries.’

Dashrath was badly wounded; bursts fired at close range had ripped into his stomach and he was unconscious when the Chinese finally overran his position. Under the circumstances, as the senior JCO, he had managed to control the Rajput response remarkably well. In all, there were seventy-five